where we reach in the next six months." Others take heart from the fact that the number of parties has increased from 15 in Patna to 26 in Bengaluru. Never mind that eight of the 11 new entrants have no presence in the Lok Sabha.

THE NDA RETORT

While the electoral strength of INDIA remains untested—in its current form, it won 135 LS seats—it has certainly roused the BJP-led NDA camp from its dormancy of the past four years. The emphasis, during the July 18 conclave, was categorically on reclaiming the BJP's monopoly on "nationalism", expressed with trademark eloquence by the PM himself: "The NDA is a rainbow of regional aspirations that puts the nation first and is trusted by India because it is a formation with a positive agenda and wasn't conceived to grab power."

It was also a rebuilding exercise since the alliance has lost three significant members—the Janata Dal (United) in Bihar, the Shiromani Akali Dal in Punjab and the Sena (even if the Shinde-led faction is back in the BJP fold) in Maharashtra. There was also a distinct attempt to placate the allies, some of whom have been unhappy with the BJP's tendency to play "big brother". Appealing to their sentiments, the PM said: "In the past nine years, it is possible that I couldn't give you time due to my busy schedule.... Despite this, none of you ever complained and always loved me. This is my biggest asset. We will keep working for the welfare of the public."

After the first meeting of the Opposition parties on June 23, the BJP opened new channels of communication with several former allies as well as a few fresh ones, such as actor Pawan Kalyan's Jana Sena Party in Andhra Pradesh. By a common reading, it stands strengthened in Maharashtra after the split in the NCP and coopting the Ajit Pawar-led faction, leaving Sharad Pawar, one of the stalwarts of the Opposition camp, sufficiently embarrassed. (An opinion poll, though, predicted a sympathy-based uptick for the MVA.) Meanwhile. Chirag Paswan's Lok Janshakti Party (Ram Vilas) and Jitan Ram Manjhi's Hindustani Awam Morcha Secular (HAM-S) in Bihar, and Om Prakash Rajbhar's Suheldev Bharatiya Samaj Party (SBSP) in Uttar Pradesh are back in the NDA fold.

There could be some more homecomings. In Andhra Pradesh, the BJP is in talks with N. Chandrababu Naidu's Telugu Desam Party (TDP), which was part of the NDA till 2018. At the same time, however, it doesn't want to annoy Y.S. Jagan Mohan Reddy's YSR Congress Party (YSRCP). Though not a BJP ally, YSRCP's support has been crucial for the BJP to pass several bills in the Rajya Sabha. An alliance with the TDP may also backfire in neighbouring Telangana.

SOON AFTER THE FIRST OPPOSITION MEET IN PATNA, THE BJP OPENED CHANNELS OF COMMUNICATION WITH FORMER ALLIES AND EVEN POTENTIAL FRIENDS ON THE OTHER SIDE

For Modi, it's not just about winning but winning with enough safety. Under no circumstance does he want the BJP count to go below 272, the majority mark, leaving the party at the mercy of allies. The stated objective is to take the collective vote share of NDA allies from 45 per cent in 2019 to 50 per cent, a feat no party or alliance has achieved in independent India. The hidden agenda, however, is to work out the seat-sharing arrangements in such a way that the BJP's strike rate remains intact, if not actually climbing. Amid embraces and handshakes with the leaders of the alliance partners during the Delhi meeting, Modi laid bare his intent: every constituency and every vote will count and even the smallest party could make the difference between victory and defeat in the battle. BJP insiders say the support of these parties can help the BJP candidates get the caste combinations right and win in areas that may otherwise slip out of their grasp because of a split in votes.

For instance, the inclusion of Rajbhar's SBSP, which has considerable influence among the Rajbhars in 10-12 districts of eastern Uttar Pradesh, may help the party earn the support of that community. To ensure more consolidation, the BJP has also facilitated the return of MLA Dara Singh Chauhan from the Samajwadi Party to the BJP as he has clout in several districts overlapping with Rajbhar's pocket boroughs.

It's this desperation not to split the vote that is making the BJP seek alliances or send feelers to potentially mobile elements in the Opposition even in areas where it is strong. In Haryana, where the party won all 10 Lok Sabha seats, it is in talks with Dushyant Chautala's Jannayak Janata Party (JJP), which is an alliance partner of the BJP-led state government but is not officially part of the NDA. The JJP wants to field candidates from two Lok Sabha seats. And after splitting the NCP, the BJP is sending feelers to Rajya Sabha member Jayant Chaudhary to merge his outfit Rashtriya Lok Dal with the saffron party. While the Jat leader has been offered a berth in the Yogi Adityanath cabinet, the BJP sees this as an opportunity to strengthen its presence in western UP, particularly among Jats who were upset over the three contentious farm laws that the Centre had to eventually repeal.

Irrespective of who stays where in the final battle in the summer of 2024, both sides will be fighting for their respective ideas of India. And it will be the voter who will decide which idea of India, or Bharat, they will back while moving forward. ■

with Anilesh S. Mahajan